Called to
Edit

How to build a career as a

Video Editor and Get Paid

From your first lesson to your first paying client, and every step between.



Samuel Adebayo
VIDEO EDITOR AND COACH

INSIDE THIS BOOK

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START HERE

There are millions of video editors. Why you?

This book answers that question. It is everything I wish someone had told me when I started, from learning the skill to getting clients who pay you, in the order you will need it.

This is not an editing tutorial. The buttons are free on YouTube; I learned 80 to 90% of what I know about editing there. What YouTube hardly teaches is the career around the skill: what to learn first, how to get seen, how to get clients and how to get paid. That is this book.

> **Editing is cutting out what is not needed from the raw idea and presenting it in a way the viewer can get it.**

MY DEFINITION OF VIDEO EDITING

Video editing is broad. There are movie editors, podcast editors, short-form editors

and motion graphics animators. I can't teach you every kind of editing, but I can show you the pathway, and the pathway works whatever kind you do, wherever you live.



Each chapter decides the next. Your niche decides your tools and what you learn; being seen is what makes getting clients possible. The bright stops are where most of the work is.

How to read this book

- Read it in order the first time. Each chapter builds on the one before.
- **Remember** boxes hold the one thing to keep from a section.
- **Do this** boxes are your homework. They are where the results come from.
- **From my journey** boxes are my own stories, mistakes included.
- The last pages are the whole book on one page. Come back to them.

Money: amounts in US dollars (USD) are what clients paid me. Amounts in Nigerian naira (NGN) carry a rough dollar figure at October 2026 rates, so you can compare them with your own country.

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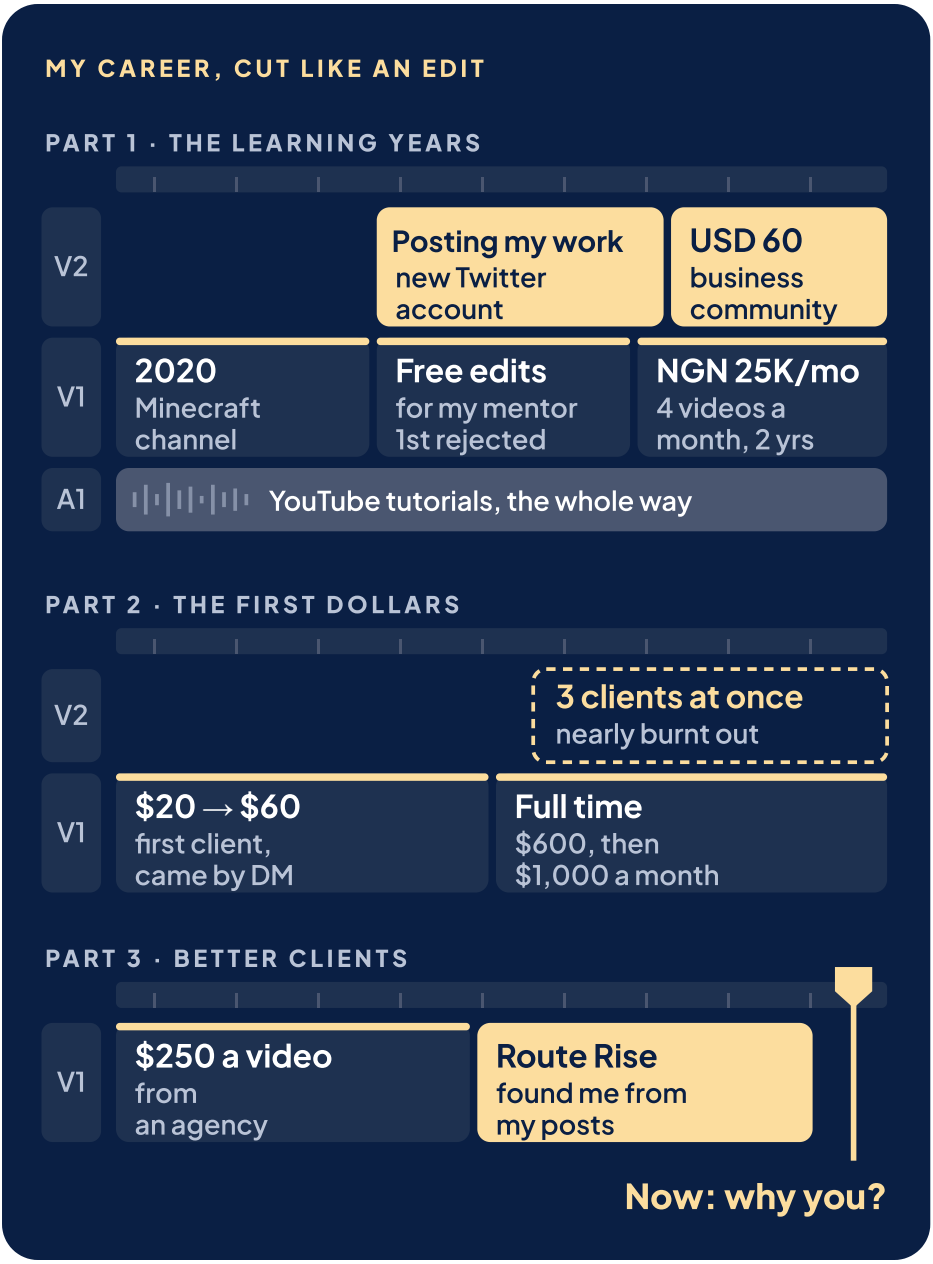
CHAPTER 1

My story

From a soldier with a hobby to an editor paid by clients abroad.

“People watch what you do. People watch what you post.”

I went from zero to being paid by clients abroad, working from Abuja, Nigeria. I didn't get there by talent. I got there by real work, by being seen, and by a lot of mistakes.



Two things ran under everything: learning from YouTube, and posting my work. Every jump in pay came from real work or from being seen.

It started as a hobby

In 2020, during COVID, I was still a soldier. I learned editing for myself, for my Minecraft

YouTube channel. I had a laptop and wanted free software, so I found DaVinci Resolve. If I had known CapCut then, I might have started there, but I'm glad I started with Resolve. Later I edited for my church.

A few years later I asked myself: *what can I do better than just being a soldier?* I looked at different skills and picked editing, because I already knew a little.

The best move I made: working for free

When my mentor opened a YouTube channel, I offered to edit his videos for free. I only knew how to cut. I had spent a whole month's salary on a laptop that was decent but laggy. It was enough.

MY FIRST THREE EDITS FOR MY MENTOR



Edit 1

REJECTED

"I can't use this."



Edit 2

NOT YET

Back to YouTube to learn more.



Edit 3

UPLOADED

It went live on his channel.

I learned from tutorials I watched to deliver a video that was going live, not to practise.

At first I wasn't paid. Then he gave me **NGN 25,000 a month** (Nigerian naira) for data and expenses, for about **4 videos a month**. I did it for **two years**, because it was making me better.

Putting my work out there

My mentor told me to put my work out there. I opened a new Twitter account, posted my work and networked with editors on Twitter and LinkedIn. Seeing their work showed me I had to step up. I locked in for six months, mastered Resolve and learned the business side.

I paid **USD 60** out of my salary to join a community that taught the business of editing, not just the skill. That is where I learned that the career around the skill is what makes you succeed, and the psychology behind every edit choice. I asked editors questions, slid into DMs, got rejected and kept learning.

The first dollar

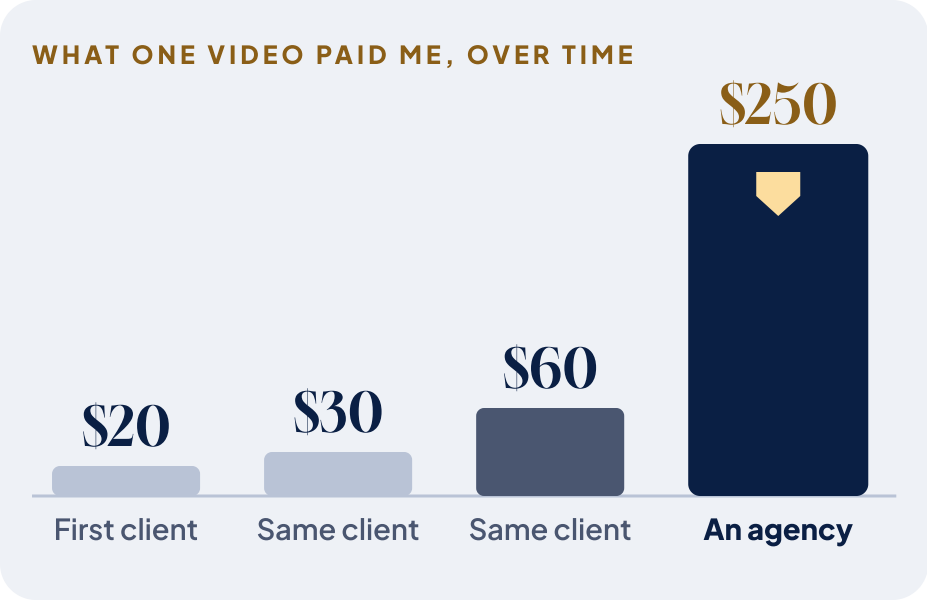
My first client came to me by DM. He had been watching my posts. He paid **USD 20 per short-form video**, my first dollar payment. I didn't even know how to turn dollars into naira. The same client went to **USD 30**, then about **USD 60** a video. I worked days in the military and edited at night.

Going full time

Then I quit the military to edit full time, one of the riskiest things I have ever done. I had some savings and a place to stay in Abuja. My first month paid **USD 600**, my biggest payout then. The second paid about **USD 1,000**.

I took on three clients at once and nearly burnt out. That taught me that **more clients does not**

mean you are better. I went after better clients instead. An agency paid me **USD 250 per video**.



Per video, in US dollars. The jump came from better clients, not more clients.

I kept posting. **Route Rise reached out to me** because they had been watching my work. They are the biggest company I have worked with so far. Through them I have edited for a YouTube channel with 1 million subscribers and a billion-dollar company.

What it taught me

I'm about four to five years in now, with lots of mistakes and trial and error behind me. I wish I

had known two years earlier what I know now. Having worked with the big players, I know that not everything matters. This book is the things that do.

REMEMBER

The skill gets you in. How you present it is why you get hired. There are millions of video editors around the globe. The question is: why should they hire you?

- Video editing is not just a skill. It is a way of passing information and communicating.
- A lot of people put effects in a video without understanding what purpose they serve.

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CHAPTER 2

The truth about the market

There is huge demand for editors. Most beginners never earn because nobody who pays can find them.

“A diamond is as valuable as it is visible.”

Every brand, creator and business now needs video. You can't run a proper business today without putting something out there on the internet, and the people running those businesses are busy. They will pay someone to edit.

5.66B

social media accounts in the world, about 7 in 10 people

DATAREPORTAL · OCT 2025

200B

YouTube Shorts views every single day

YOUTUBE · JUN 2025

3B

people use Instagram every month

META · SEP 2025

500+

hours of video uploaded to YouTube every minute

YOUTUBE · 2019

50M creators

in the world, and only about 4% earn over USD 100,000 a year. Millions of creators, few with a professional workflow. Someone has to cut all that video.

GOLDMAN SACHS RESEARCH · 2023

Who pays editors

There are three kinds of creators, and they don't pay the same.

ENTERTAINMENT

Skits, gaming, dance

Plenty of them. They live on views and brand deals.

Pays least

EDUCATIVE

Teaching and explainers

Most are business people, teaching you toward a product.

Pays well

BUSINESS

Founders, brands, companies

Post a lot, find it tedious, already understand marketing.

Pays the most

The people who pay you are **creators, businesses and agencies**. An agency is a middleman: one agency may have 20 to 30 clients and employ many editors.

Agencies	GOOD FOR BEGINNERS Always have work, and give you clients you could never reach yourself. Agencies really helped my career. But they pay less, because they take a cut, and they give the worst feedback and many revisions, because they are trying to perform the video so their client will love it.
Creators, businesses and brands, directly	THE BEST The best pay and the best working relationship. You have to find them and earn their trust, which is what this book is about.

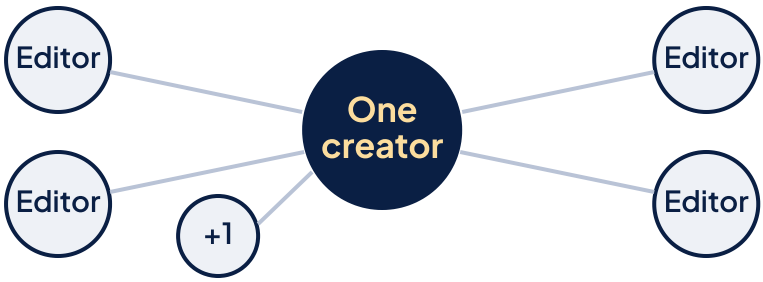
YOU WORK YOUR WAY UP THE LADDER



Big brands and big creators go to agencies; they hardly work with individual editors. Brands don't employ random people. The ones who can't afford an agency are where you start.

"But the market is full"

No, it isn't. **Some creators have three, four, five video editors.** The problem is that most of us are not good enough yet, and we don't position ourselves so the people who need us can find us.



One creator, several editors. The work is there. Visibility is the gap.

The biggest beginner mistake is learning a lot of skill and never positioning yourself: not using social media to get clients, putting random things in a portfolio and applying for jobs. Applying has its place, but only after you have a strong social media presence and portfolio. Before that, social media is where you build. My own biggest mistake was not putting myself out there.

AI is not taking your place

Yes, AI can edit. But most people don't even want to spend time asking AI to edit their videos. Your leverage is **the skill plus AI in your workflow**, so you deliver faster and more easily. The company I work with demands that its professional editors use AI. Clients need editors who are up to date, and creativity is still needed. If you don't know how to use AI in your workflow, you will fall behind. In this age, much of what you learn today can be useless tomorrow, which is why knowing *what* to learn matters more than ever.

REMEMBER

A diamond is as valuable as it is visible. You can't be a video editor without being visible, because video editing is literally a visible skill.

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CHAPTER 3

Editing is a service

You learn a skill, but you sell a service, to a specific person. Everything after this chapter rests on that.

“If you are targeting everyone, you have no one.”

Business is an exchange of value for money, literally. I serve you by editing your videos and you give me cash for it. That's business.

A SKILL

"I can edit videos."

True of millions of people. Nobody knows what to buy from you.

A SERVICE

"I edit YouTube videos for business creators so they get more views."

A specific person knows you are for them.

This is where most editors get stuck. They learn the skill, leave it as a skill, and never package it as a service or show a client why they need it. Talented editors miss this all the time, because they focus on the skill and not on how to serve the client.

So ask: how can I offer this, and who can I offer it to? You need an **ideal client**. Not everyone is your client.

Not everyone is your client

Think about a clothing business. It can't dress people in Japan and China at once, because they dress differently. So it picks one group.

TRYING TO DRESS EVERYONE

Japan, China, Nigeria, Brazil...

Different styles, different sizes, different tastes. Nobody feels it was made for them.

PICKING ONE GROUP

"I sew clothes for Nigerians."

Now every choice is easy: the fabric, the cut, the price, the advert.

Editing works the same way. Your target audience decides **how you pitch**, and it decides **what you learn**: you improve your skill based on what suits the people you serve, not on what you would like to learn.

Many editors never made it because they wanted to edit for everyone. As a beginner you think, *I'm just starting, I'll take as much as I can get*. But you can't edit for everyone, and you need to start somewhere. Serve everyone and you end up like every other editor. Be specialised, not generalised.

Your tools decide who you can serve right now

If you edit on a phone, you can't serve someone who needs long YouTube videos. They may be your dream client, but your tools don't get you there yet.

> FROM MY JOURNEY
>
> I wanted to be a motion designer. But my laptop was very bad and I didn't have the money for a better one. So I didn't chase it. I chose what my tools could do, and that is what got me paid.

Work backwards

Don't start with the skill. Start from two things you already know: **the tools you have** (your phone, your computer, CapCut) and **the person you want to serve** (YouTubers, Instagram creators, real estate agents). Those two decide what you go and learn. Then you package that skill as a service for that person.

START HERE

The tools you have

phone, laptop, software

AND HERE

Who you will serve

one specific kind of client

The few skills you learn

nothing your tools or client don't need

The service you sell

packaged for that one client

REMEMBER

Video editing is not just a skill, it's a service. Your tools, your skill and your target audience decide what you can serve.

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CHAPTER 4

Choose your niche

Pick a niche you enjoy, one that makes money and values marketing. Then say it in one sentence.

“In any niche, business people pay more.”

You need to niche into something before you even pick your skill. The niche decides who pays you, how much, and what you need to learn.

Who pays: my ranking

In any niche, business people pay more, because they already understand marketing.

SaaS, software and AI companies	TOP Those people have money. They can pay you a lot.
Real estate, marketers, logistics, solar, service businesses, personal brands	VERY GOOD Real estate agents have money. Businesses that sell a service know what a good video brings them.
Educative creators	GOOD Most of them are business people teaching you toward a product.

Entertainment, gaming, skits, dance

LOWEST

To be honest, they are mostly broke. They live on brand deals, adverts and sponsorships, their margins are thin and depend on views. By the time they hit about 1 million views and can pay, they already have a good editor. Fine to start with; not where the money is.

THE FOLLOWER TRAP

BUSINESS CREATOR

10K

followers. Can make USD 100,000 a month, because he markets to them.

Can pay you well

ENTERTAINER

100K

followers. May not afford USD 500, or even USD 100, per video.

Struggles to pay

Followers are not money. Ask what a creator sells, not how many people follow them.

Two more to watch:

- **Corporate companies** hire you like a normal employee on fixed pay, whatever value you generate, and you can't negotiate. It's still a chance to work, but I always advise against

it. I prefer **solo creators and small businesses that make money**: easier to negotiate with and more flexible.

- **Low-ticket sellers**, creators selling something cheap, may not make enough to pay an editor well.

The niches at a glance

SaaS, software, AI tools	HIGH product explainers, demos, founder talking heads, ads
Personal finance, investing	HIGH talking heads, explainers
Business, marketing, coaches	HIGH talking heads, podcasts, course promos. My niche.
Real estate	HIGH property tours, agent talking heads, ads
Ads, in any niche	HIGH the best-paying short form
Education, explainers	GOOD tutorials, documentaries, AI and tech
Podcasts	DEPENDS business podcasts pay

Vlogs, lifestyle, fitness, beauty	DEPENDS on whether they sell something
Events, weddings, church	VARIES event recaps suit phone editors
Gaming, skits, dance	LOW gameplay, highlights, trends

Advertisers also pay the most on YouTube for finance, business and software videos, which is why those creators can afford you (vidIQ, most profitable YouTube niches).

How to choose yours

1. **What excites you most, and what do you watch most?** I watch a lot of business videos, so I understand how they are edited.
2. **How much does this niche usually make?** Can they afford an editor?
3. **Do they value marketing?** That's why business people are always the best: they already understand why marketing matters.
4. **Can your tools handle it?** That is the next chapter.

Short form or long form?

LONG FORM

$500–2,000

per video is a price you easily hear in long form. It pays more per video.

SHORT FORM

5–10

videos a month in one package. Less per video, so you sell volume.

Ads are the best-paying short form. An ad is tied directly to the customers a business gets, so it is easy to measure how your video performs. I know editors who edit ads, and they make a lot of money. A short-form editor can earn more than a long-form editor if they know how to package their work well (Chapter 10).

Say it in one sentence: your offer

Stop saying “I'm a video editor.” There are too many kinds. Say exactly what you are: “I am a long-form video editor who edits business videos for YouTubers.” Then turn it into an offer. There must be a promise.

YOUR OFFER SENTENCE

I help who get what result in how long through how.

Who: the specific people you help. **Result:** more views, more sales. **How long:** a time range. **How:** video editing, motion design, storytelling.

My example: *"I help business creators get 10,000 views in 3 months through video editing and visually engaging content."* Always make sure you are specific.

DO THIS

Write down what editing service you offer, to whom (the person you would love to work with), which kind of videos, and how you will package and sell it to them. Then write your offer sentence.

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CHAPTER 5

Your tools and the money to start

Start on what you can afford, never on cracked software, and treat every cost as capital you will earn back.

“Whatever you pay for a subscription is your capital.”

Your niche and your hardware pick your software. If you don't have the hardware for a piece of software, don't chase videos that need skills only that software gives you.

ON A PHONE

CapCut, Premiere Pro mobile, Edits

Free to start, with paid tiers. Great for short form, captions and simple social videos.

ON A LAPTOP

DaVinci Resolve, Premiere Pro + After Effects, CapCut Desktop, Final Cut (Mac)

Resolve is free, Premiere is paid. Needed for long form, colour and motion.

- **DaVinci Resolve:** a great all-rounder, especially for colour grading. Free, but it needs a laptop that can run it. Colour grading is part of editing, and some people sell colour grading alone.
- **Premiere Pro + After Effects:** the best for heavy motion design. Resolve can do it, but these work best. Paid.
- **CapCut:** the free version is good and enough to get you paid work, but most professional tools need Pro. If you can

afford a laptop, start with CapCut on the laptop, depending on your niche.

- **Edits (phone):** I use it, especially for Instagram-style music.

Where phone editors win and lose

PHONE LOSES ON	PHONE WINS ON
Long-form YouTube	Event recaps
Motion graphics	Simple short form
Heavy animation	Talking heads cut into shorts with captions
	Social videos with captions, overlays, screenshots

You can't compete with a computer editor on heavy work. Many phone editors add animations because everyone else does. The phone editors I see succeeding are the ones doing event recaps and simple social media videos. **Focus on where your power can handle.**

Invest in your software

FROM MY JOURNEY

I once used a cracked copy of Premiere Pro while trying to move away from Resolve. I'm not joking: my computer was hacked, and it affected my client work. I went straight back to Resolve. **Never use cracked software.**

THE SOFTWARE LADDER

Free version
I used free Resolve for client work for two to three years

→

Paid version
then bought Resolve Studio, paid for by the work it got me

- **Phone editors: pay for CapCut Pro.** If you don't have the money, borrow it for the first subscription, then work hard that month to earn the next one.
- **AI tools depend on your niche.** I pay for Claude now, but a beginner shouldn't pay for a tool they don't need. Other paid tools exist, like ones that cut long form into short forms. If you need one, invest, then make a profit quickly to cover it.

REMEMBER

Whatever you pay for a subscription is your capital. Once you see it that way you think, “I'm already spending capital, I need to start making profit,” and that pushes you to pitch.

What editing really costs

Video editing is expensive. You can start for free, but it's not really free.



Software
subscriptions



Data
very important



Electricity
power, fuel, solar



Storage
drives fill fast



Headphones
to hear the edit



Microphone
for your content

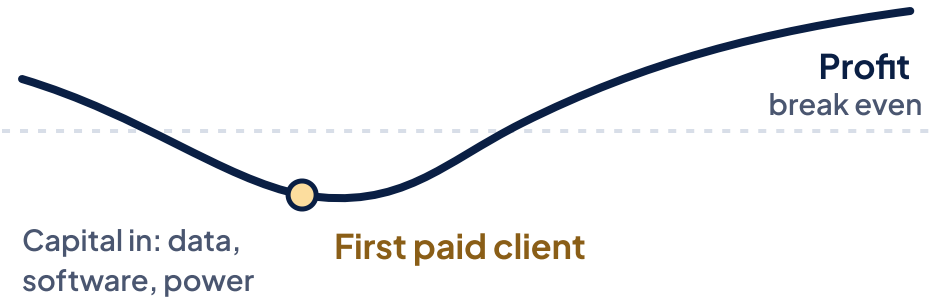
Even a phone editor needs data to watch tutorials, download videos, upload and show their work, and power to keep going.

There is no fixed price to start, because everything varies by country and by what you already own. If you have a phone and can afford data, you can start. My first laptop cost

a whole month's salary at the time. Later on, things change.

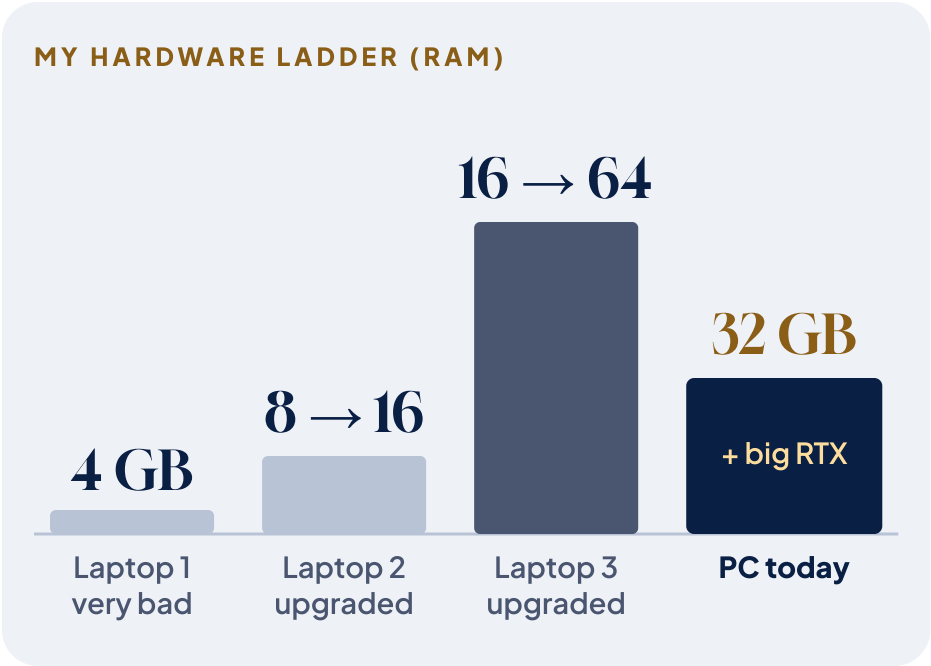
Treat your first one or two months as capital, an investment in your business and your skill. That is why you move from free to paid work fast (Chapter 7): paid clients cover the cost, then you break even, then you profit.

WHY THE FIRST PAID CLIENT MATTERS SO MUCH



The computer you need

For DaVinci Resolve, the minimum is **16 GB of RAM, an SSD and a dedicated graphics card (GPU)**. These are expensive, so start with what you have and pick niches it can handle. Proper colour grading, for example, can't be done on a phone.



I upgraded RAM instead of buying new laptops. Buy a laptop you can upgrade.

- **Don't wait for the perfect machine.** Some people say they'll wait until they earn NGN 1 million before buying their first laptop. That will take a while. If all you can afford is an NGN 300,000 laptop (about USD 220), buy it and use it until you can move to an NGN 600,000 one (about USD 450).
- **Mac** laptops (M1 and newer) are the best for editing. I couldn't afford one, so I used Windows. If you can, save up for one: it will make your life easier.
- A bad laptop will frustrate you, but it can still edit some kinds of video.

REMEMBER

Don't spend your editing money on yourself yet. Putting my earnings back into my tools was one of the fastest ways I grew.

NEXT

Chapter 6: Learn the skill the right way

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CHAPTER 6

Learn the skill the right way

Start with who you serve, what they pay for and what your tools can do. Then learn one skill at a time, on a real video.

“You don't choose what to learn. What you learn is chosen for you.”

You don't choose what to learn. What you learn is chosen for you by a few filters. Work backwards through them and cut what you don't need, until you know exactly what to learn.

FOUR FILTERS DECIDE YOUR LEARNING LIST



1 **Who you want to work for, and what kind of videos.** Be very specific. Platforms edit differently: a YouTube talking head and an Instagram talking head are not the same thing. TikTok is different again, and so is LinkedIn. Short form is not long form.

2. **Who can actually pay you.** Business videos pay more than entertainment (Chapter 4).

3. **Your hardware:** phone or laptop, and how strong it is.

4. **Your software:** CapCut can't do 3D motion graphics, so why learn that skill?

YOUTUBE

Vlogs, business talking heads, reaction, gaming, podcasts, storytelling, cinematic

INSTAGRAM

Reaction, talking heads, storytelling

TIKTOK AND LINKEDIN

Each with its own pace and style

ADVERTS

A category of their own, tied directly to sales

Each kind of video needs different skills

Real estate	A lot of tracking and animation
Business talking heads	No tracking or animation needed
Storytelling	Some need visual effects

Adverts	Their own skills; some need visual effects
Some videos	Don't even need sound effects

WORKED EXAMPLE: A PHONE EDITOR DOING PODCAST RECAPS

LEARN

- ✓ Cutting
- ✓ Sound design
- ✓ Typography
- ✓ Captions

SKIP, FOR NOW

- ✕ Motion graphics
- ✕ Heavy storytelling
- ✕ 3D effects

FROM MY JOURNEY

When I started, I wanted to learn everything. I'd see a flip animation and want to learn it. It was overwhelming, until I chose YouTube long-form business talking heads. Then I had to learn long-form editing specifically. I loved motion graphics, but my laptop couldn't handle it, so I dropped it. Some things you pick up gradually as you go, but you need to niche down to know the major things.

REMEMBER

Don't learn what you won't be able to pitch to your client. Everything looks exciting. Motion graphics is fine to learn if it serves your audience and your tools can handle it.

The four foundations

Every paid edit, in every niche, stands on four things.



Software and skill are two different things

THE SOFTWARE

Master it first

The one you will actually use. For CapCut, sit through the long 4 to 5 hour tutorials. You can't skip this part.

THE SKILL

Then learn the craft

The art of cutting, pacing and sound that makes the kind of video you chose.

The mistake is learning the software and thinking that's editing. I mastered DaVinci

Resolve; there's nothing you can tell me about Resolve that I don't know. But the software was only the start. Your tool stack grows as you go, for example CapCut plus an AI tool.

AI is part of what you learn

- AI is a tool in your stack, depending on the videos you edit.
- It can't do cinematic, heavily animated videos yet. It can handle some simple talking heads and even some kinds of motion graphics, and on a laptop it can cut your videos for you.
- I use Claude (Claude Code) in my own workflow to edit parts of my videos. A friend of mine works with a client whose short forms are all edited by AI.
- If you can afford AI tools, use them, pitch them, and **charge the client for the cost of the AI tools** you use on their work.
- Learn each AI tool the same way you learn editing: one at a time.

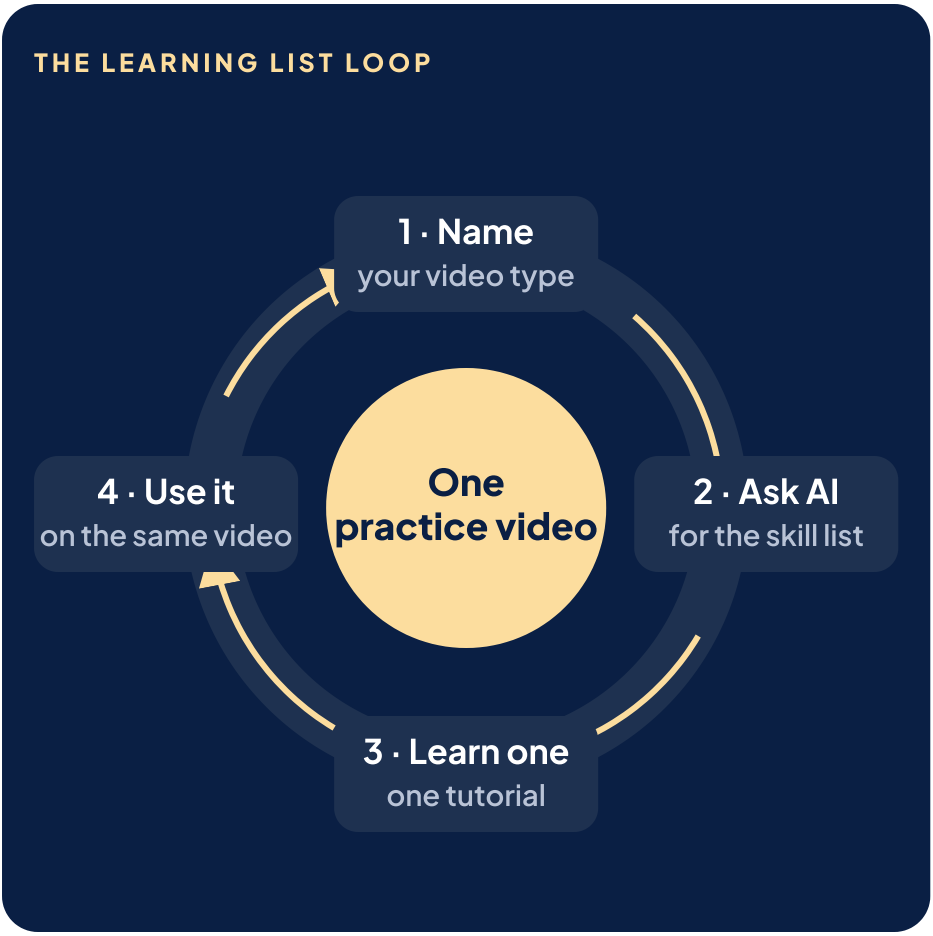
AI IS ALSO A PITCH

“I use AI to enhance your videos faster, so you can put out content faster.”

Some creators and business owners need speed more than fancy edits.

Where to learn: YouTube

I didn't learn the skill anywhere other than YouTube. There is nothing you want to learn that you won't find there, and I never paid for a skills course. The problem is never the source. It's the search. People think one video can teach them all of video editing. It can't: video editing is broad. What you search for comes from your filters.



Go round the loop once per skill on your list. When the list is done, you have a finished video and skills you can sell.

1. Name your video type, for example *talking-head business videos for Instagram creators*.

2. Ask any AI tool: *"What are the skills I need to learn to edit talking-head videos for business creators on Instagram?"* It gives you a list: cutting, pacing, captions, a little typography, overlays and outlines, B-roll, sound design, music.

3. Learn them **one by one**. One tutorial for one skill.

4. **Use it straight away** on one practice video: a full video from YouTube, or one you record of yourself on your phone. Learn cutting, cut that video. Learn typography, add it to the same video. Then sound design, then a little motion graphics, all on the same video.

REMEMBER

Don't learn without implementation.

- **Learn as you work.** In the middle of an edit and don't know a transition? Search YouTube for it, or describe the transition you saw to an AI and ask how to do it. When a client asks “Can you do this?”, I say yes, then learn it while doing that project. I learned on the go more than from watching tutorials.
- **No single teacher.** I learned from many creators, each for what I needed at that moment, never one creator from beginning to end.

- **Make tutorials your entertainment.** There was a time I opened YouTube and watched tutorials for fun.
- **What wastes your time:** learning something you won't implement, and watching one long general tutorial instead of learning skill by skill.

FREE, ON YOUTUBE

The skill

Everything you can pay for in a course, when it comes to the skill, is on YouTube.

WORTH PAYING FOR

The business

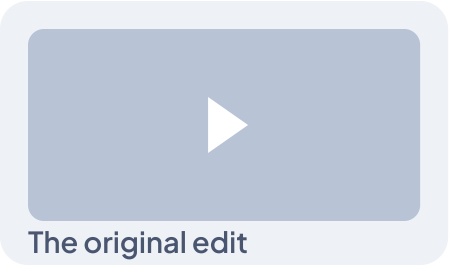
Talking to clients, packaging and presenting yourself. I learned it from marketers and sales people, not editors.

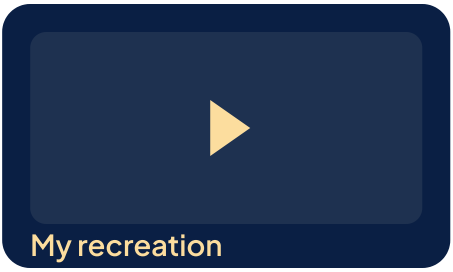
If you don't know what you want to learn, that's when you end up paying for courses, and most of the time you won't implement them.

Recreate videos you love

Recreating edits in your niche is one of the fastest ways to learn, and I did it a lot.

POST IT LIKE THIS





“I just recreated this edit. Did I get it right?”

1. Pick your niche, for example podcast videos.
2. Find an edit you love, for example a short form someone cut from a podcast.
3. Find the raw podcast on YouTube and download it.
4. Copy the same edit.
5. When you hit something you can't do (an animation, a 3D effect, the sound design), search YouTube for that one thing, learn it, then put it in. There's a YouTube tutorial for everything you want to do. I promise you.

- **Raw footage:** YouTube is a mine of raw videos; many people post unedited ones. Skip the biggest creators: their videos are

already over-edited. Look for raw videos close to your niche.

- **Share it** side by side with the original. Lots of editors post recreations.
- **It's practice, not portfolio.** You can't really call a recreation your own.
- **Why it works:** you're copying what someone already did professionally, so that one day you become like that person. You can't ask the editor how, so you have to work it out.

Edit for the goal, not to look edited

Every video has a goal. Know it. A business video's goal is to turn viewers into clients. You measure your work by whether the video achieved the reason the client posted it.

THE FLASHY VIDEO

Lots of views

No sales

Views the client can't use for anything.

THE CLEAR VIDEO

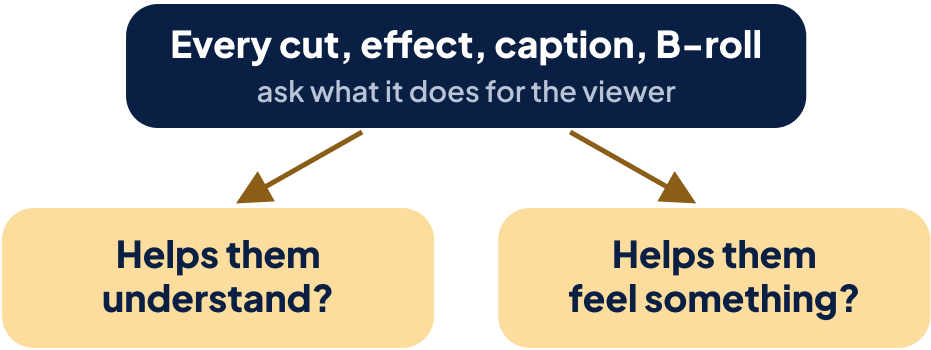
Fewer views

Lots of sales

Made for the right audience. Which would your client rather have?

Ask: what is my client trying to achieve? What is their audience looking for? What's the best thing this video presents? Build the edit around that. If the client's goal really is views, hit that.

THE FUNCTION TEST



Yes to either: keep it.
No to both: cut it.

Sad music that carries the emotion of a story works. Sad music plastered on for no reason doesn't. A transition has to play a role in the story. B-roll is there to help the audience see what is being said, not to make the video look edited.

Show, don't tell

Whenever the client says something you can show, show it.

WEAKER



A car icon

The viewer reads a symbol.

STRONGER



Real car footage

The viewer sees the real thing.

A real thing always beats a fake thing. Talking about YouTube views? Show YouTube views. A meeting? Show the meeting. For my clients, whatever they explain, I visualise, with motion graphics and explainers. Some of my videos are about 80% showing what the client says rather than the client's face.

What viewers hear and see must match. The voice helps them follow; sound effects carry feeling; the visuals show what is being said. A car sound needs something car-related on screen.

Master one niche and you learn the ingredients that make its videos get results. Platform matters too: TikTok is fast, and Instagram and YouTube each edit differently. Hold the viewer's attention.

REMEMBER

A client will choose an editor whose videos produce results over one doing flashy edits that don't perform.

NEXT

Chapter 7: From practice to paid

Called to
Edit

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CHAPTER 7

From practice to paid

Finish three full videos in your niche. Then get onto real people's videos: free at first, then a token, then paid.

“When you can finish a full video from beginning to end, you're good enough to charge.”

There's no fixed time before you're ready. It's about your skill level. When you can finish a full video from beginning to end, the kind you want to be paid for, you're good enough to charge. Not one: three.

THE READY TEST

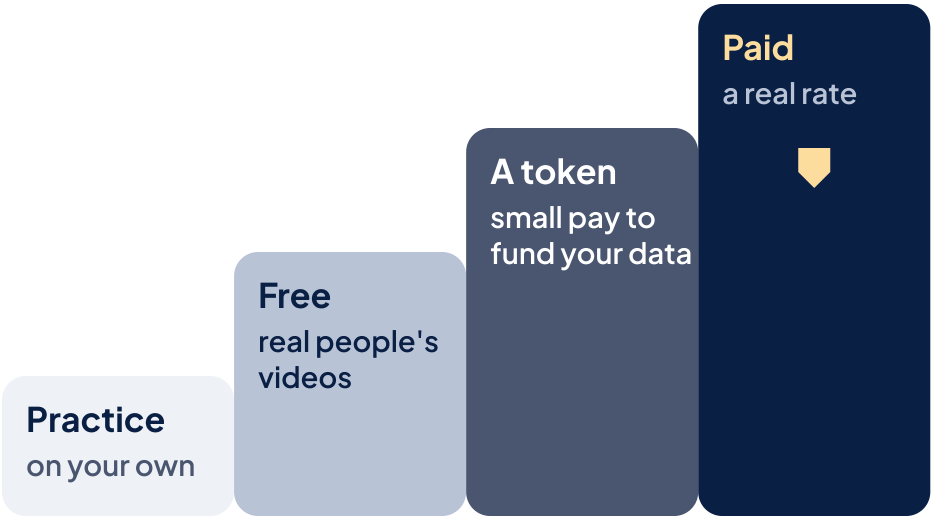


Three complete videos in your niche, start to finish. Then you are ready to charge.

Most people wait too long because they never finish a whole project. They learn nuggets and specific styles, not full projects, so they don't know how to put it all together on a real video. Finish one, two, three full projects and you build the confidence to take on a real person's video.

The ladder from practice to paid

CLIMB IT QUICKLY



1. **Practice videos:** your own, like two or three talking heads of yourself.
2. **Real people's videos, for free.** As soon as possible, move from practice to real projects:
   - a friend who owns a business: “Record a video for your business, let me help you edit it so you can post it.”
   - an event you attend: capture it, edit it, show them so they can use it
   - small businesses near you without the budget for an editor

- small creators, or a friend making content in the style you want to edit

3. **Ask for a token.** If they're enjoying it, tell them you'd love to be paid a token for it.
4. **Charge.**

Offer free help, but still put your work out there as a paid service. If someone sees your practice videos and asks “How much do you charge?”, don't say “I'm not ready.”

Why real projects teach you fastest

My number one way to learn is working on **real projects that have real consequences, for real people**. The reason is pressure.

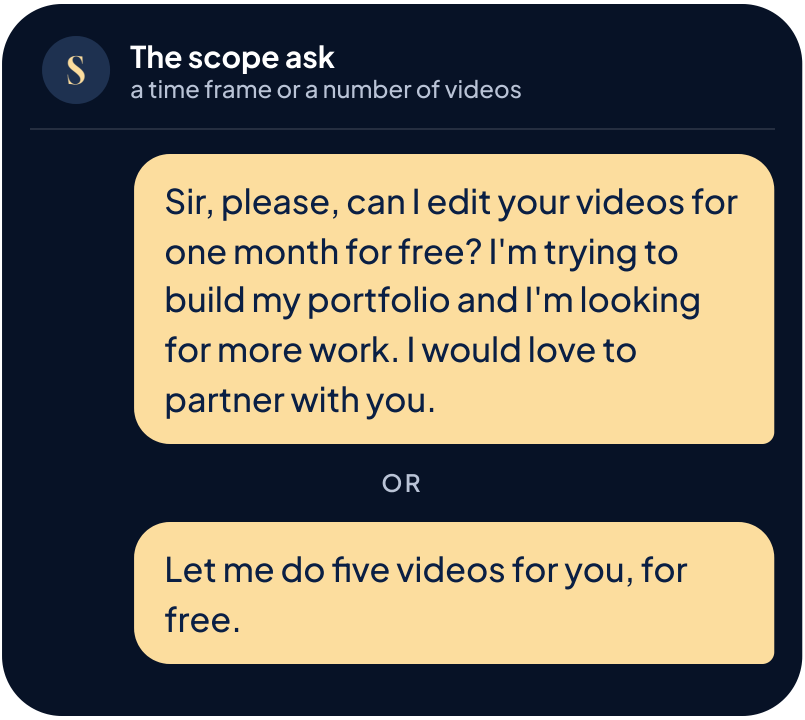
YOUR PRACTICE VIDEO	A REAL PROJECT
No deadline	**They post it tomorrow**
You can spend a whole month on one video. Nothing is at stake.	You try your best not to make mistakes, so it converts and gets views. It keeps you up late.

To get real projects as a beginner, offer your service free to people who can manage you as a beginner, where excellence isn't critical yet.

Work for free without getting stuck there

1. **Free** is the best way to start.
2. **Low pay** comes next, once you're more confident and have done real work, even a small amount (in Nigeria, NGN 5,000 or 10,000: a few dollars). It still makes you better, and it pays for what learning costs: data and electricity. Free or not, you still need data.
3. **Don't stay free too long.** After **four or five free projects** for one person, start moving to paid, unless you have an agreement. Many of us spend too much time learning and working for free, and that's why we can't afford the little things we need.

You hear editors say they earn big monthly figures. You are not there yet. You are still in the learning stage, and at that stage you need enough money to fund your skill.



- Set the scope up front. Never “free for a year”.
- **Don't tell them you're learning. Tell them you're building your portfolio.**
- **You don't have to raise the money conversation.** With a scope set, when it ends they know you either leave or they pay you. If you did a good job, they know they may not find someone as good, and they will want to pay you to stay. Then you agree a new deal. If they won't pay, you can leave for another client.

FROM MY JOURNEY

An editor once worked for me free for a whole month. After that, I started paying them. That is exactly how it works when the scope is clear and the work is good.

What free work gives you

MY "FIVE YEARS OF EXPERIENCE"



3 years free, at most NGN 25K a month **then paid**

Nobody knows the first three were free. It still counts.

Testimonials
People won't know it was free.

A portfolio
Real work to show.

Experience
Years that count.

Confidence
You've done it before.

Referrals
Happy people talk.

Sharper skills
Pressure teaches.

REMEMBER

You have to learn to humble yourself and work for free. Most people think they need to get paid. You want to get better.

Called to
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CHAPTER 8

Get seen

No one who learns from me succeeds without visibility. Pick one platform, show who you help, and post every day.

“You can't succeed in this industry if you are hidden.”

For my first two or so years, nobody taught me the importance of visibility. Editing is a visible skill. To prove you're credible, you have to show your work. That's your selling point. That's your marketing. That's your advert.

“

Where can people find you? When they need you, where can they see your work?

THE QUESTION MY MENTOR ASKED ME

I had nowhere to show it. So I opened brand-new Twitter, LinkedIn and Instagram accounts and did two things.

1

I curated my feed

I searched “video editors” and followed every major editor I found: about 50 on Twitter, and many on LinkedIn and Instagram. My feed fed me editing all day.

2

I posted my work

I recorded myself working, photographed my timeline, screenshotted everything I did in a day, and posted no less than 3 times a day.

If you want to build something around a niche, surround yourself with that niche. For your first month, lock in: make all your social media about editing, especially your niche. It's a secret most people don't know.

That visibility is what actually made me successful. No matter how good you are, if no one knows, it doesn't count. When people think of your name, they should think of what you do. Announce it and be unashamed.

REMEMBER

Showing your work is your leverage.

Pick one platform and own it

Pick one platform and focus on it; two if you have the capacity. Become the known person for your niche there. If you are a real estate editor, be the best real estate editor anyone can find on that platform.

Twitter (X) and LinkedIn	BEST FOR BEGINNERS Agencies and clients search here, and it's where you meet other editors. Low effort: text and screenshots, no face needed. **Where I got clients:** mostly international agencies and companies.
Instagram	BIG IF YOU PUT IN THE WORK Builds your personal brand and a mini portfolio at once. Harder: your face, your voice, and editing your own videos on top of client work. Best once you have a foundation. **Where I got clients:** a mix of international and Nigerian.
TikTok	PERSONAL BRAND Your face and your story, like Instagram. **Where I got clients:** a lot of DMs from people near me, in Nigeria.
Facebook	NOT FOR THIS One of the worst places to build a personal brand as an editor. Low-paying, frustrating clients.

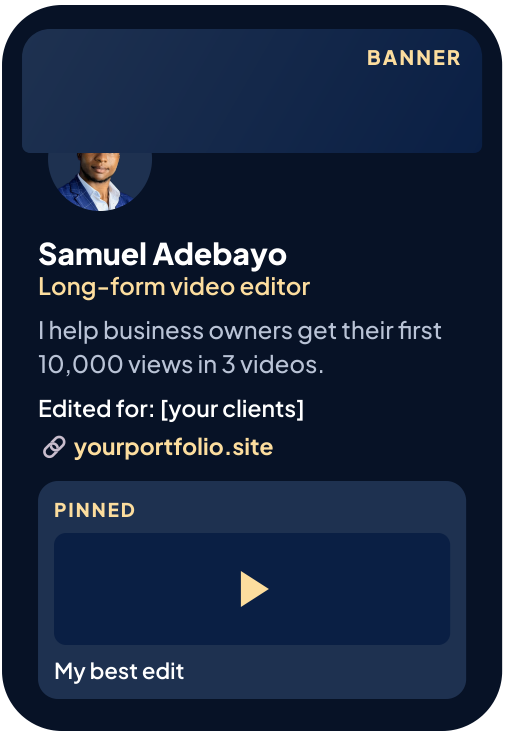
HOW AGENCIES HIRE EDITORS



Individual clients do the same. The fastest way for me to find an editor myself is LinkedIn and Twitter.

I hardly got Nigerian clients on Twitter, probably because I mostly followed and engaged international editors. Who you engage shapes who finds you. Whatever your niche or format, there are business clients on every one of these platforms. I have now moved fully from Twitter to Instagram to build my authority and personal brand.

Build your profile



1. **Your face.** People trust who they can see.
2. **Name + what you do.**
3. **Bio = your offer** (Chapter 4).
4. **Clients** you've edited for.
5. **Portfolio link**, always.
6. **Pinned post** = your best edit.
7. **A good banner.**

A lot of us hide ourselves. Show your face, often. Be specific in your bio about the result, how fast and how. Pin the edit you're proudest of, so the first impression is “this person is a professional.”

Build a personal brand

This is the AI age. People impersonate others, copy posts and generate them with AI. Clients need to know you are a genuine, real human.

So post your life around video editing, and nothing else for now. You can post about politics or football, but right now you're building a reputation.

A normal day
You working, you on a call with a client.

Your story
My soldier-to-editor story hits every single time.

Struggles
A client who turned you down.

Wins
A new client, a new laptop.

Challenges
“Day one of trying to get my first client. Day two. Day three.”

THE 40 / 40 / 20 RULE



- **40% Authentic** story, behind the scenes, wins and failures
- **40% Authority** teach: “3 ways to get a client”
- **20% Sales** “I'm looking for a new client”

Authentic posts build emotion. Authority posts prove you know what you're doing. Sales posts pitch you. For your niche, an authority post can be: “Business owners, these are the mistakes in your videos: 1, 2, 3.”

Post at least 2 to 3 times a day. I posted 3 times a day for 60 days, and it built my engagement.

700

followers on Twitter. That's all I had.

Best

clients I needed came from those 700. Followers don't matter as much as you think.

Your portfolio

A new client can't scroll through all your posts. A link in your bio takes them to where all your

work lives: an archive of your work, and proof you're someone they can work with.

A SHARED DRIVE FOLDER

Click. Wait. Click.

Friction. They think "I'm not ready for this" and go to another editor.

A SIMPLE WEBSITE



They just watch.

Your videos, one page, no effort. That's all a client wants.

The best portfolio you can have is a website. It doesn't need to be flashy or built by a web designer. What the client wants to see is your videos, not a flashy website.

Build it with AI, in one night:

1. Upload your edits to YouTube as unlisted videos.
2. Copy the links.
3. Paste them into an AI: *"These are the videos I edited. Use these videos to create a portfolio that I can link in my bio."*

Claude does this very well; ChatGPT and Gemini can too, even on free plans. I built mine

on Framer in one night, using code and AI. I did that once, and it got me clients.

Framer (mine)	A free site on a Framer address. The best-looking sites; video-editor templates exist. Takes time to learn.
Canva Websites	A free site on a Canva address. Easiest if you already use Canva.
Carrd	Up to 3 simple one-page sites free. The simplest: a showreel and a few videos.

WHAT GOES IN IT



Your top 4 and your other 4. Eight at most. Only have 3? Put the 3.

- Before and afters
- Testimonials: screenshots of what clients said
- Results: screenshots of what you got for clients
- About you: who you are, how long you've edited

Whenever a client asks for your work, send your portfolio. Too many videos gives the client too much work.

> **Your practice work is your work. I repeat: your practice work is your work.**

IF YOU HAVE NO CLIENTS YET

Free work and practice on real people's videos count. It's their footage, but the edit is yours: it's your work, and you're not posting it for views. Recreations stay practice. Replace practice pieces with real projects as they come.

Look the part

Pick brand colours and stick to them. Mine was green: in all my old posts, I always used green. Use Canva for banners and packaging your profile; I eventually paid for Canva for this. If you don't understand branding yet, don't disturb yourself too much. It comes gradually.

DO THIS

For the next month: curate your feed around your niche, fix your profile with the 7 points above, build a simple portfolio site, and post 2 to 3 times a day. Always show your work, as much as possible.

NEXT

Chapter 9: Get clients

Called to
Edit

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CHAPTER 9

Get clients

Skill, a strong personal brand, a strong portfolio, outreach and a network of editors. Done together, consistently.

“Getting clients is a lot of hard work. That's the truth.”

If you skipped being specific about your niche, or skipped being visible, getting clients will be hard. The people you reach out to will check your page before they reply. If your page is empty, they won't even reply.

INBOUND

They come to you

"Hey, I saw your work. How much do you charge?"

OUTBOUND

You go to them

You see someone whose videos you could edit, and you reach out.

Do both. You can't rely only on inbound, and you can't rely only on outbound. Established editors get more inbound; beginners have to go looking.

Inbound: make them come to you

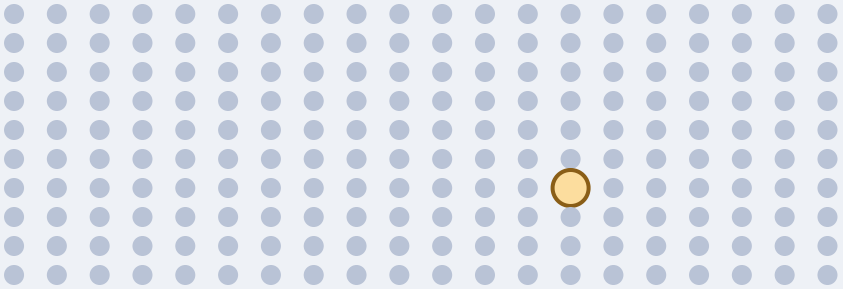
Inbound only comes from work on your personal brand. What makes a client DM you instead of another editor:

- **Showing your work,** and how you came up with it.
- **The person behind it,** your personality. Being specific makes you unique.

- **Reliability.** Clients are tired of editors who can do flashy edits but aren't reliable and miss deadlines. So **document your day**. People don't only look at the fancy videos; they want the behind the scenes.
- **Credibility:** testimonials and the results your work brought.
- **Posting consistently,** not once a week, not once every two or three days.

> FROM MY JOURNEY
>
> I used to post time-lapses of myself working. A client scrolled my profile, saw my day-to-day, and said exactly this: “This guy is locked in.” That's what reliability looks like from the outside.

THOSE 200 VIEWS



One of them could be your client.

Or one of them knows your client and recommends you. Many people recommended me to clients just because they followed me on Twitter.

I can't give you my money if I don't trust you, and your content builds that trust. Be patient: one, two, three months of consistency. Once other editors comment on, follow and like your posts, clients follow, because if you are valuable to other editors, you are valuable.

REMEMBER

There are a lot of clients looking for editors. You are invisible. That's why they can't find you.

Outbound, part 1: warm outreach first

Warm outreach means people who already know you: friends, family, colleagues making

content, people in your DMs and contacts, and other editors you know. **Warm outreach converts the fastest,** because they already know and trust you.



- Even a relative who works in a bank may know someone.
- If you know editors who are already busy, tell them you'd love to edit for them.
- **Beginners: work with someone first, whoever it is,** free or low pay. It may not be your best payer, but without results and evidence, high-paying clients won't consider you. They want to see experience. They don't see knowledge.

DO THIS

Do one warm outreach after reading this chapter. Research who to reach first, then send it.

Outbound, part 2: find cold clients

Cold outreach is people who don't know you yet. It takes research and warming up. Go where your client is: for YouTube clients, search YouTube for creators in your niche. Watch their videos and understand what they do. Scroll past the many who already have great editors.

THE THREE SIGNS OF A POTENTIAL CLIENT

1

In your niche

The videos you chose to edit.

2

Makes money

In some form, so they can afford you.

3

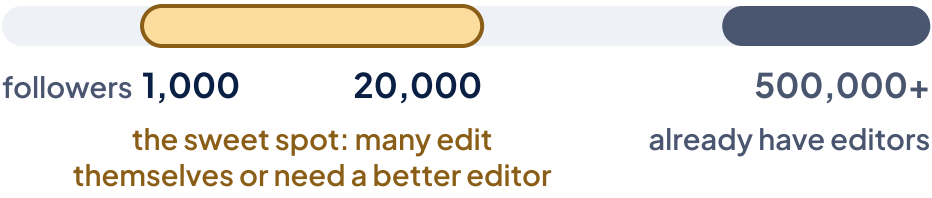
Needs an editor

Weak, badly edited or unedited videos.

Find their email: on YouTube, many creators list one on their channel. Then find them everywhere else (Instagram, LinkedIn, Twitter),

note the kind of content they make, and save examples to use as references. Even well-edited creators may need an extra editor.

ON INSTAGRAM, GO SMALLER



The dream client list

This is the most important thing for every video editor. Make a table in Notion (I always recommend Notion) or a spreadsheet. You are gathering leads here, not reaching out yet.

ONE ROW OF YOUR LIST

Name	Joshua
Channel or handle	@joshua_b2b
Email	from his YouTube About page
Other platforms	Instagram, LinkedIn, Twitter
Content	B2B SaaS explainers, long form
Followers	8,400
Example videos	3 links saved
Follow-ups	✓1 ✓2 ☐3 ☐4

A made-up example row. Joshua is the example creator I use throughout this chapter.

- Aim for **20 to 50 names**. Mine was **100: my dream 100**, built by hand before AI could research.
- Keep adding every day until you land your first dream clients.
- Keep two lists: **potential clients**, and **clients** you already work with.

YouTube itself	A channel's About page shows a business email when the creator added one. Free.
Channel Crawler	Search YouTube channels by niche, country and subscribers. Search free; emails paid.
TubeMailer	A Chrome extension that pulls public business emails from YouTube. Free to try.
Modash	Finds creators on Instagram, TikTok and YouTube by niche and size. Free trial, then paid.

If you can pay for it, AI agents can research for you. ChatGPT on its own won't give you the best results; agent tools like Claude Code, Codex and Grok can. I pay for Claude Code,

about NGN 33,000 a month (around USD 25), and I have an agent that pulls potential clients for me from YouTube, Instagram and TikTok.

Agencies are clients too. Most of them post on Twitter and LinkedIn that they need an editor. Good for beginners while you work your way up (Chapter 2).

Warm them up before you reach out

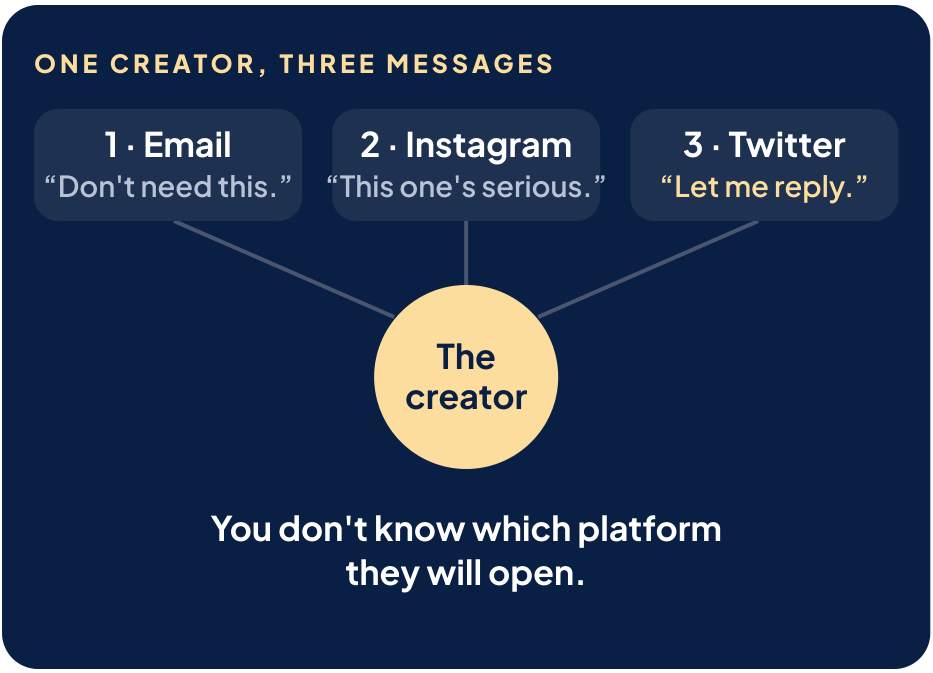
BY THE TIME YOU DM, YOU'RE NOT A STRANGER



“Who is this person?” They check your page.

Turn on notifications for the creator. Be the first to comment, and say something genuinely good about what they teach. After **4 or 5 posts**, especially with smaller creators, they notice you: “this person likes my content.” Comment enough and they check your page. They see you're an editor, and if they need one right then, they may reach out first.

Then reach them on every platform

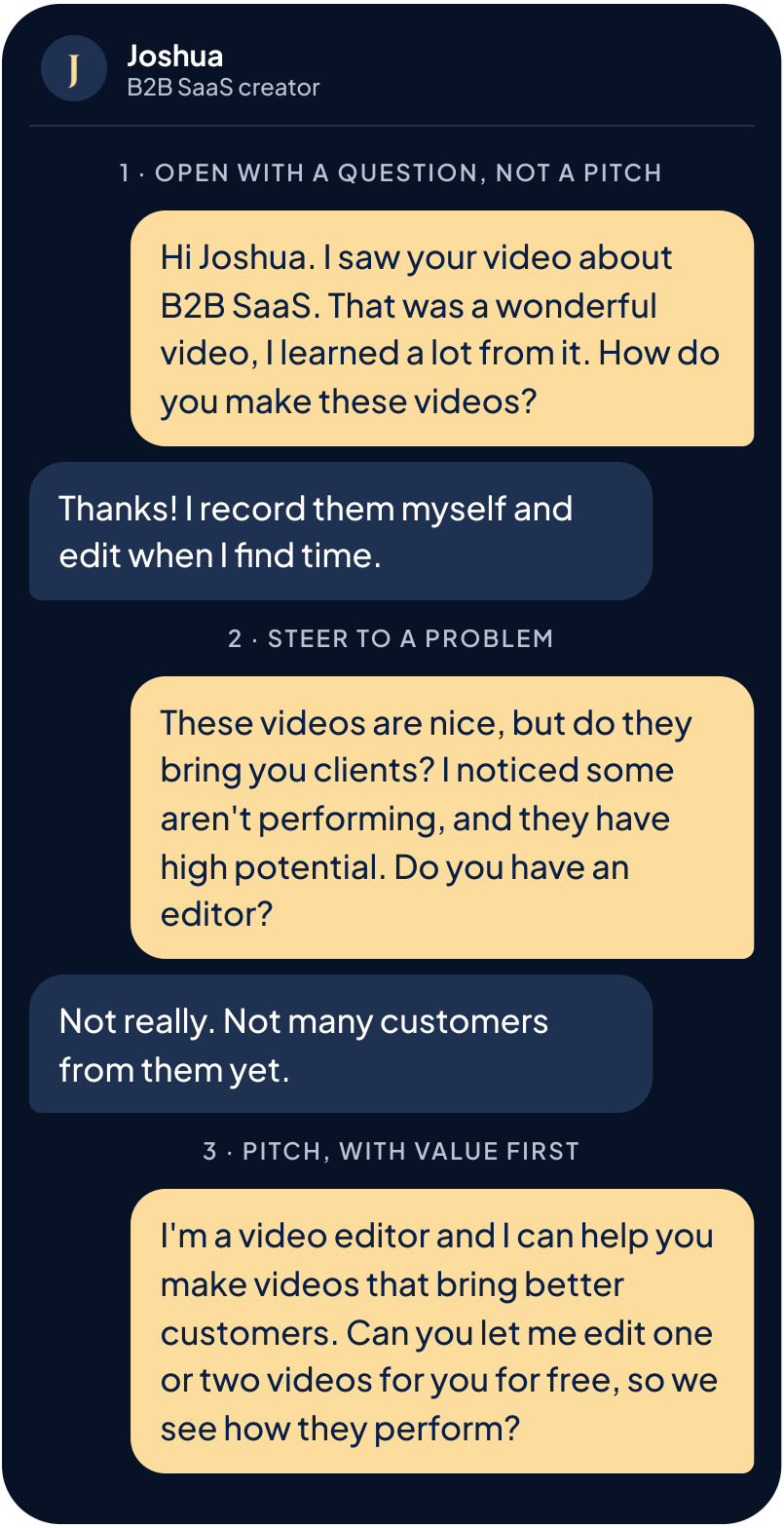


I emailed each of my 100 one by one, then sent the same person an Instagram DM, then a Twitter message. By the third, they think: this person really means business.

Cold DMs: talk first, pitch later

Why most cold messages fail: “Hey, my name is Samuel, I'm a video editor, and I'd love to work for you. Here's my portfolio.” You are too cold. You just want their money, and you show no interest in what they do.

Research the client properly first, and leave two or three genuinely good comments. Take your time: it can make or break your career.



An example of how the conversation can go. Even when they don't need you, they reply more politely (“Right now I don't have

the money for an editor"), and that leaves you room to follow up.

- A question lowers their guard. There are a lot of scammers out there; a curious, casual person is not one.
- They decide whether to post the free edit. You need to learn to give value.
- **In DMs, send voice notes.** People want to hear real human beings. Others paste AI-written messages; your voice makes you stand out. Send your picture and your portfolio too.

Cold emails: be specific in one message

An email isn't a conversation, so prove you watched their video.

To: Joshua
Subject: Your video on 5 ways to get healthy

Good day, Joshua. I just saw your YouTube video about 5 ways to get healthy, and I love it. I noticed it isn't performing well. Do you have an editor? I feel your videos can perform better in this way, that way and this way. I would love to do a free edit for you. Let me know.

Name the video. Not “I saw your videos” but “your last video about 5 ways to get healthy.” Better still, mention something from 10 minutes in, so they know you watched it. The more research you do on the person, the better the replies.

Value first: edit their video before they ask

Don't wait to be offered a free trial. Download one of their videos, re-edit it and send it. They see you've already put in work.

NEVER MORE THAN 30 SECONDS

0:30	the rest of their video: leave it

Before / after. Email it, then post it and tag them.

- If you edit a full minute in the name of value first, you're wasting your time: you have other people to reach, and this one may say no.
- Pick a video you can visibly improve. Don't take a well-edited video and add things that don't make sense.

- Email it: “I did a free edit for you. Check it out.” **Also post it on Twitter and tag the creator.** They may miss the email and see the post. Other creators see it too, and sometimes someone else wants that edit for themselves.
- It gets attention and it's good practice. But it takes time, your edit has to be really good, and it sells how fancy your edit is, not everything else you bring, like making videos that convert.

Loom: pitch yourself on video

Subject: I recorded a video to explain some things for you



- Loom lets you record a short video of yourself and send it as a link. I pitched myself on camera instead of in text. They see a real person who took the trouble;

most people now use AI to automate emails. People relate to videos.

- **Stack it:** a value-first edit and a Loom together, or the edit first and a Loom as the follow-up. They see how serious you are. They may not need you today, but they'll remember you tomorrow.
- **Loom is for email.** In Instagram and Twitter DMs, send voice notes.
- Link your best video, not only your portfolio. I linked my best edit on Twitter, so clicking it took them to my page, where they saw me working hard.

Follow up

SPACE THEM OUT. STOP AT FOUR.



FIRST FOLLOW-UP

"Hey, just checking whether you saw my last message. I'd really love to know what you think."

After the 4th with no reply, move on.

Don't give up because one message got no answer. By the third, try: “I realise you must be busy. But I really love your videos, and I still feel I can be of good help.” Be kind every time, and tick each follow-up in your list. Many people advise 2 or 3; my limit is 4, because I have other people to reach. Old-school editors say “follow up till they say no”; I only do that for a client I really want.

Close on a call

As soon as possible, get that client into a video call. I repeat: as soon as possible. The closer you are to them, the easier it is to close. On a chat I can tell you no and not care. On a video call, before I say no, I'll reconsider.

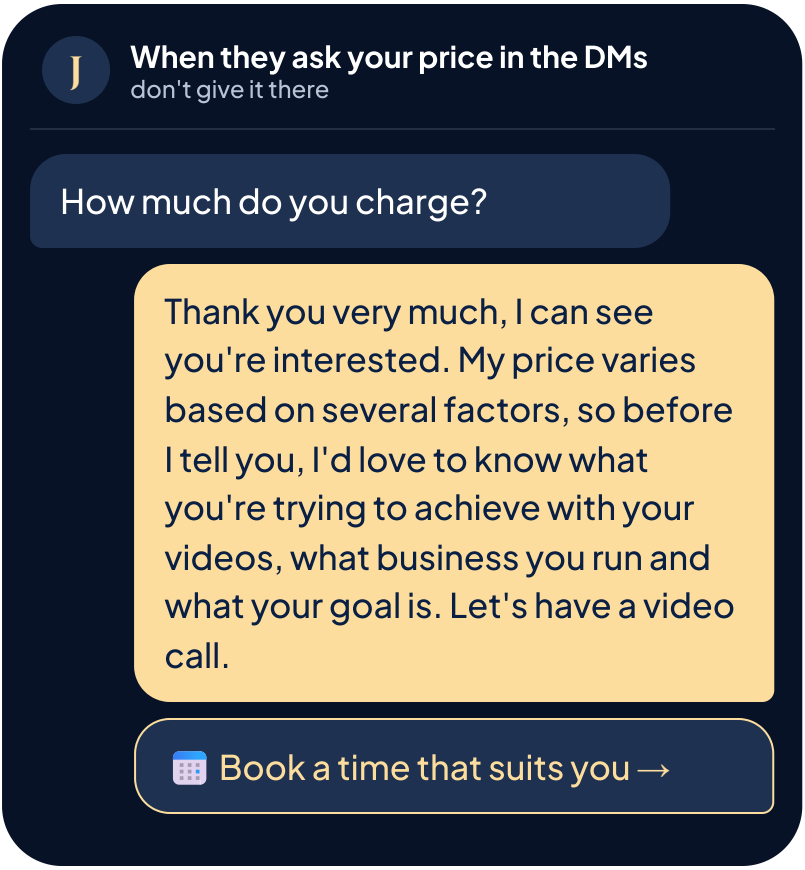
THE CLOSING PYRAMID

rare: most are remote

harder to say no



In person is strongest but rare; it's why CEOs fly between countries for meetings. Aim for the video call: they see a real person, not a bot. Voice notes at least let them hear you're real. Once feelings are attached, negotiations land more often.



Send a calendar booking link so they pick a time that suits them. Pricing itself is the next chapter.

The weakest routes

I used these. They didn't work for me, but some editors do succeed with them. Know them, and don't rely on them.

“Looking for a video editor” posts	ABOUT 80% SCAMS My least favourite. Editors, some automated, flood the replies within minutes. I recommend it with a 0.1% chance. Some real companies do post on LinkedIn.
Free communities and Discord servers	FULL OF SCAMMERS USD 2 edits, people asking you to send money, links that are viruses. Real jobs are in **paid** communities: I got one or two clients from VP Plus, a paid community.
Job sites	DOESN'T WORK One editor job post can get about 5,000 applicants.
Upwork and Fiverr	RACE TO THE BOTTOM If you're not the best editor there, you're the cheapest. Saturated.



Your skill must be good; you can't dodge that one. Then a personal brand that shows your personality and hard work, a portfolio (that's why you work free at the start), outreach (value first, Loom, good emails, comments, warm-ups, conversations) and other editors. Good skill with a weak brand or no outreach just makes you slower.

REMEMBER

Don't rely on one means. Do it all consistently for one, two, three months, for many clients, and there's no way you will not land one.

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CHAPTER 10

Price yourself and get paid

Price per video from a rate card, price what the video is worth to the client, get to packages fast, and protect yourself.

"Stop collecting single projects."

A lot of us price ourselves wrongly. The fix starts with how you count: per video, never per minute, never like a salary.

✓

Per video

Per project. How freelancers charge.

✗

Per month

That's a salary. Companies pay wages.

✗

Per minute

Length doesn't measure the work.

SAME WORK, DIFFERENT LENGTH

A 1-minute video



dense cuts, motion, captions

A 20-minute video



A one-minute video can have as much work as a 20-minute video. If a client offers to pay per minute, don't take that deal.

Have a rate card

One card that shows your price tiers by what's in the video. The client sees your real prices, and you can budget around them together. Mine, as a long-form editor:

RATE CARD

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1 **Under 20 minutes**
Simple cut, talking head, a few captions

2 **Under 20 minutes**
Motion graphics, B-roll, research from me

3 **Over 20 minutes**
Motion graphics

Put your own price on each tier. The tiers are what matter: the client sees what changes the price.

What sets your number: your skill level, how confident you are that you can deliver, and the kind of client.

A BEGINNER, LEARNING

$5–10

per short-form video, for simple work you're learning on

GOOD INTERNATIONAL CLIENTS

$20–30

per short-form video, what they used to pay

What moves your price

There is no fixed price. Think of it like a mixing desk: every fader moves the final number.



- **Your skill and confidence.**
- **The client's business,** and how much the video matters to it. Some videos are very important to them and need a lot of work.
- **What the video is for.** A paid advert is directly tied to money. Business videos: always charge more.
- **The work inside it:** animation, motion graphics, B-roll, research. For

documentaries, look at what the video actually needs.

- **The niche** and **the length**.
- **Revisions.** Set them in the deal, for example "a video with 3 rounds of revisions."
- **The result you get them:** the sales the video should bring.

Take control of the price

1. **Ask questions first:** "Do you want motion graphics? What style of video? What do you want to achieve with this?" They see you know what you're doing.
2. **When they say it's too much, explain why:** "There's motion graphics in this," or "This video has to reach an audience that can buy your product, so I'm doing more research."
3. **Price on a call** (Chapter 9), so you can negotiate properly.

Clients who demand your price in the DMs get angry when you hold it back. They're comparing you with other editors and looking

for the cheapest. You don't want to stoop that low. If you've tried everything and they flatly refuse a call, give them your flat price and let them decide.

REMEMBER

Don't be afraid of no's. Don't be afraid of rejection. It's part of the journey.

Stop collecting single projects

Pitch several videos at once. It's easier to sell a full package than one video after which they have to come back to you.

LONG-FORM PACKAGE

$5,000

5 long-form videos a month

SHORT-FORM PACKAGE

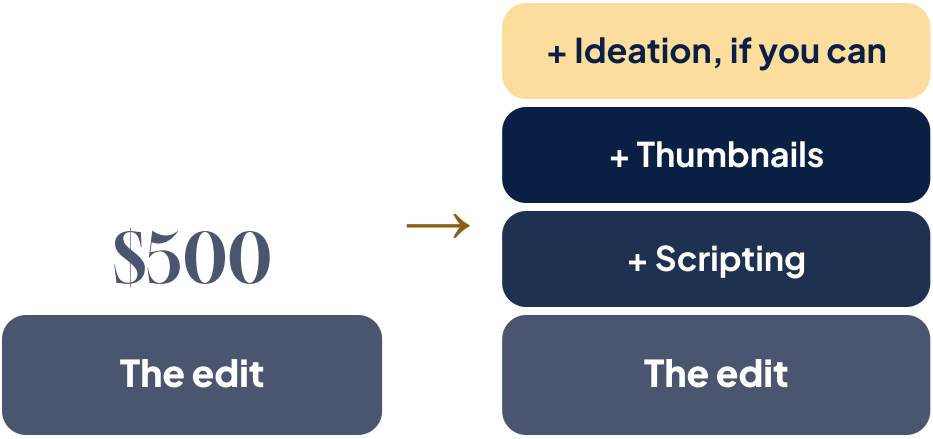
$3,000

30 short-form videos a month

- **Mine now:** 3 to 6 videos a month for my client, paid at the end of the month for the videos done.
- **Packages need a retainer client:** someone who already posts consistently and works

with you over a long time, so you know the money comes back every month.

UPSELL AFTER YOU LAND THE CLIENT, NOT BEFORE

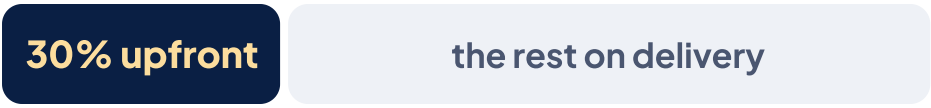


Offer ideation (only if you really know how), scripting or thumbnails on top of the edit, so the client pays USD 1,000 instead of USD 500.

Don't get scammed

The scam is simple: you deliver the video and never get paid. It happens a lot in this industry.

ON EVERY NEW CLIENT OR BUNDLE



If they never pay the rest, you already have something.

1. **Take about 30% upfront** before you start, especially from people you don't trust yet.

2. **On a new bundle, always.** If you agree 20 or 30 videos a month with a new client, don't wait until all 30 are done for the first payment.

3. **Write a contract and have them sign it.** Not something they just said or typed in a chat. You each keep a signed copy.

Agreement · example

5 videos a month
30% paid upfront for the 5
Balance paid on delivery
3 rounds of revisions per video

Client signature _____ Editor signature _____

Once you've worked with a client for a long time, you can trust end-of-month pay. My long-time client pays at the end of every month, whatever the count.

Getting paid from abroad

What works depends on **where you live and where your client is**. US clients pay differently from Canadian ones. Research what works between your country and your client's, and

ask people near you who already earn online. What works for me might not work for you.

In Nigeria, receiving payment from abroad has been very difficult. I've used Payoneer, then Grey, and for the past two years **Cleva**. I've used Western Union before, but I don't think it works for this anymore. Here is what I found, as of October 2026 (fees change, so check inside the app):

Cleva (mine)	A US dollar account; convert to naira. Small deposit fee, no conversion fee reported.
Grey	USD, GBP and EUR accounts. Good for UK and European clients.
Raenest	A USD account built for freelancers. Fees vary; check in the app.
Payoneer	For Fiverr, Upwork and clients who already use it. Usually the dearest route into naira.
PayPal	Not a way to get paid in Nigeria: accounts there are mostly for paying, not receiving.

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CHAPTER 11

Grow through people

Your biggest clients come through trust: results you can show, and people who know you.

"You can't do video editing alone."

One of the most important assets you have is real testimonials and real results from your previous clients. Clients love to work with people who are already experienced and have worked with others.



1. **Document the result for every client,** for example the views their videos got.
2. **Keep screenshots** of those results.
3. **Turn them into case studies.**
4. **Ask for a testimonial:** written, where they type out what you did for them, or video, where they record themselves saying it. Video is very powerful.



Views on my mentor's channel. It's not much for YouTube, but it really helped: it went into my portfolio and my case studies, even though the work was free.

Some of us have worked with people and never asked them for a testimonial. Go and ask.

DO THIS

Ask one past client, or anyone you have edited for, for a testimonial this week.

Network with other editors

Other editors are very important to your growth. This helped me a lot.



When I started on Twitter, I engaged other editors' posts: I commented, liked, talked with them and built relationships. I joined their challenges, like “10 days to get my first client”, and cheered them on. They engaged my posts back. In DMs we looked at each other's edits and corrected each other. Some became friends who sent me client projects and opportunities.

- Social media is meant to be social. Build a community of editors like you.

- **Where:** LinkedIn and Twitter are the best I've seen; Instagram works too.
- **Who:** editors at your level or smaller. Let them know you and engage with them.
- Keep your feed full of editing and editors (Chapter 8). Editors you know are also warm outreach: offer to edit for them.

2 in 3

freelancers get their work through referrals and reputation.

FIVERR SURVEY OF INDEPENDENT PROFESSIONALS · 2024

Join a serious community

Joining an editing community is one of the best things you can ever do. Mine was VP Plus, a paid community. I met some of the biggest and best editors there. They challenged me, and I saw what other people were doing. I even got one or two clients there. Be around like-minded people, and you grow.

REMEMBER

The real people who will give you opportunities are people who know you.

NEXT

Chapter 12: Your next steps

12

CHAPTER 12

Your next steps

Reading this changes nothing until you act on it. Here is everything this book asked you to do.

"Let us get into it."

Your homework

Tick them off in order. Each one is in the chapter beside it.

- [ ] **Write your offer.** What service, to whom, which videos, and your one-sentence offer.

  CHAPTER 4

- [ ] **Make your learning list** and learn the first skill on one practice video.

  CHAPTER 6

- [ ] **Finish three full videos** in your niche.

  CHAPTER 7

- [ ] **Curate your feed** and lock in on your niche for a month.

  CHAPTER 8

- [ ] **Fix your profile** with the 7 points and **build a simple portfolio site.**

  CHAPTER 8

- [ ] **Post 2 to 3 times a day:** 40% authentic, 40% authority, 20% sales.

CHAPTER 8

- [ ] **Do one warm outreach.**

CHAPTER 9

- [ ] **Start your dream client list:** 20 to 50 names.

CHAPTER 9

- [ ] **Write your rate card.**

CHAPTER 10

- [ ] **Ask a past client for a testimonial.**

CHAPTER 11

- [ ] **Start engaging editors at your level.**

CHAPTER 11

Called to Edit COMMUNITY

YOU DON'T HAVE TO DO THIS ALONE

Build it with editors who are building too

When you start putting this into practice, you'll have questions. You'll want feedback on your emails, your outreach, your profile and your niche, and a place where everyone supports each other. That's the Called to Edit Community.

- Feedback from me on your work, your outreach and your profile
- Calls with me inside the community
- The 60-day challenge: activities that take you through this book, with me guiding and correcting you as you go
- Editors at your level, building alongside you

NGN 5,000 a month

About USD 4. Open to any editor, anywhere. Find me on Instagram: @SamuelSignals

CALLED TO EDIT ACADEMY, THE FULL COHORT: COMING SOON

KEEP THIS PAGE

The pathway in twelve lines

1. Editing is a service, not just a skill. Sell it to a specific person.
2. Niche first: business, SaaS, AI and real estate pay; entertainment mostly doesn't.
3. Your tools decide what you can serve right now. Start with what you have; never cracked software.
4. What you learn is chosen for you. The software first, then the few skills your niche needs, one at a time, on a real video.
5. Every cut, effect, caption and B-roll must help the viewer understand or feel.
6. Three full videos in your niche and you're ready to charge.
7. Free work with a set scope, then low pay, then paid. Say you're building your portfolio.

8. Get seen: one platform, a profile that sells your offer, 2 to 3 posts a day.
9. A simple website portfolio with your best 8 videos or fewer.
10. Warm outreach first, then a dream client list, warm-ups, conversations, value first, Loom, follow-ups and a call.
11. Price per video from a rate card; packages and retainers; 30% upfront and a signed contract.
12. Results, testimonials and editor friends bring the biggest clients.

THE NUMBERS

Everything to remember, in figures

3
full videos in your niche before you charge

4–5
free projects for one person, then move to paid

2–3
posts a day: 40% authentic, 40% authority, 20% sales

8
videos at most in your portfolio

20–50
names on your dream client list

1K–20K
followers: the Instagram creators to target

4–5
posts you comment on before you DM

30s
the longest a value-first edit should be

4
follow-ups at most: 24 hours, 2 days, 1 week

30%
upfront, with a signed contract

1–3 months
of consistency before clients start coming to you. Be patient.

“

A diamond is as valuable as it is visible.

“

You learn the skill. You sell the service.

“

If you are targeting everyone, you have no one.

“

Don't learn without implementation.

“

Your practice work is your work.

“

They want to see experience. They don't see knowledge.



ABOUT THE AUTHOR

Samuel Adebayo

Video editor and coach
Founder, Called to Edit

Samuel learned editing as a soldier in 2020, cutting videos for his own Minecraft channel on a laptop that could barely run DaVinci Resolve. He went on to edit for free for his mentor, posted his work every day, and landed his first dollar client through a DM.

He left the military to edit full time from Abuja, Nigeria. Today he edits for international clients, including a YouTube channel with a million subscribers and a billion-dollar company.

Through Called to Edit, he coaches video editors to get paid: not just the skill, but the career around it.

FIND SAMUEL

Instagram: @SamuelSignals

Sources for the numbers in this book: DataReportal, Digital 2026 Global Overview and Digital 2026 Nigeria (Oct 2025) · Meta, as reported by Thurrott (Sep 2025) · YouTube, as reported by Search Engine Journal (Jun 2025) and Tubefilter (2019) · Goldman Sachs Research, creator economy (2023) · vidIQ, most profitable YouTube niches · Fiverr survey on referrals, as reported by Freelance Informer (2024). Tool and payment details checked in October 2026; prices and fees change.

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Called to

Edit

I coach video editors to get paid.